

文化單元 (三) Culture Notes

Six Etymological Principles of Traditional Characters



你寫的這個字是什麼字啊？



是「月」字，八月的「月」。



「月」？我會寫「月」，不是這個啊！

Traditional characters are traditionally classified into six categories (六書 liùshū) as follow;

1. 象形字 (xiàng xíng zì): pictographs characters

Pictographic characters originated from pictures of objects. They are the most ancient characters for people to understand. It is believed that traditional characters evolved from pictures. However, less than 5% of characters are pictographic.

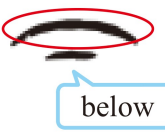
Examples:

日 ㇰ (rì)	sun	 →  →  → 
月 ㇱ (yuè)	moon	 →  →  → 
馬 ㇰ (mǎ)	horse	 →  →  → 

2. 指事字 (zhǐshì zì): self-explanatory characters

Self-explanatory characters indicate abstract meanings such as ideas or concepts that are shown with metaphorical or symbolic pictographs.

Examples:

上 ㇰ (shàng)	above	 →  → 
下 ㇱ (xià)	below	 →  → 

3. 會意字 (huìyì zì): compound ideograph

One compound ideograph character takes two pictographs or ideographs to create a new character. For example, the compound ideograph character “休 rest” is made up of “人 person” and “木 tree”, i.e., a person is leaning on the tree.

Examples:

休 $\frac{\text{亻}}{\text{木}}$ (xiū)	rest (a person is leaning on the tree, indicating “休息 resting”)	 →  →  → 
林 $\frac{\text{木}}{\text{木}}$ (lín)	grove (if there are two trees, there is a grove)	 →  →  → 

4. 形聲字 (xíngshēng zì): phonetic-semantic compounds

The phonetic-semantic compounds follow a standard principle, i.e., one element suggests the meaning of the character and the other element suggests the pronunciation of the character. For example, the phonetic-semantic compound character “媽 mā” consists of “女 women” as the semantic element and “馬 mǎ” as the phonetic element. The phonetic element indicates its original pronunciation. The majority of traditional characters falls into the phonetic-semantic compounds category.

Examples:

媽 $\frac{\text{女}}{\text{馬}}$ (mā)	mother	 女 (nǚ) meaning, women +  sound, 馬 (mǎ)
烤 $\frac{\text{火}}{\text{考}}$ (kǎo)	to bake	 火 (huǒ) meaning, fire +  sound, 考 (kǎo)

5. 轉注字 (zhuǎnzhù zì): mutually explanatory characters

Two separate characters that share the same radical, or have a similar ancient Chinese pronunciation and etymology, can explain the meaning of each other. For example, 老 (lǎo, old) 、考 (kǎo, long life) share the same radical “老”.

6. 假借字 (jiǎjiè zì): phonetic loan characters

The characters of this category were “loaned” from other characters. For example, “止 zhǐ”.